

Care about and care for

Teaching guide

Say what matters to you and who you look after.

Understand the distinction

Care about commonly means consider important: I care about the environment. Care for can mean look after: She cares for her father. Take care of also means look after or deal with.

Care for can mean like or want in some contexts: I do not care for this music; Would you care for some tea? These uses are often more formal. I do not care can sound dismissive, so choose a clearer phrase when you simply have no preference.

Compare the patterns

IMPORTANCE

I care about the result.

The result matters to me.

LOOK AFTER

I care for my grandmother.

I help look after her.

NO PREFERENCE

Either time works for me.

A considerate alternative to I do not care.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: We care ___ clean water.

2. What does care for mean in He cares for his elderly neighbor?

3. Offer a polite alternative to I do not care when either restaurant is fine.

Use it in your own life

Write something important to you and a polite way to express no preference.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. about

This expresses importance or concern.

2. Look after.

The context describes providing care.

3. Either restaurant is fine with me.

This states a preference without sounding dismissive.

One possible response

I care about arriving on time. Either cafe works for me.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-33.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write something important to you and a polite way to express no preference.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.